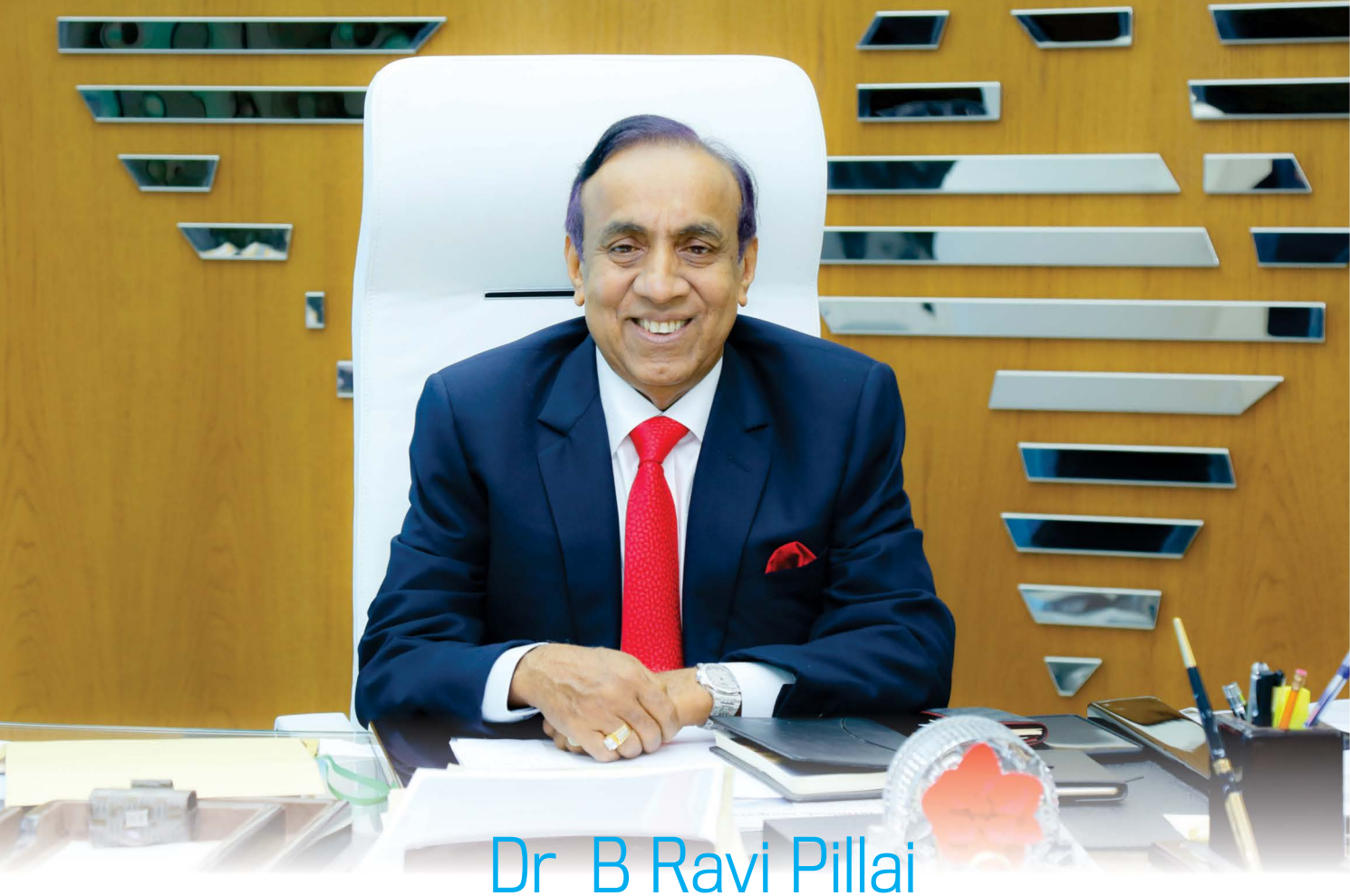


Dr B Ravi Pillai

FROM A VILLAGE YOUTH TO A GLOBAL BILLIONAIRE

70 year old Dr. B. Ravi Pillai, Founder and Chairman of RP Group based in Dubai built his business empire from a small time money lender in his home village in Chavara to US $ 3.1 billion net worth corporate group with global operations during five and a half decades. He shares his mega success story in the India Today Focus Feature.

Q You have illustrious and remarkable business career and built a global corporate giant with operations worldwide. How you feel about your journey so far?

My journey has been quite eventful, with various turning points that shaped my career. Born in Chavara, a village in Kollam district of Kerala, where my parents were traditionally farmers, I studied in the government school in Chavara and pursued my college education at Sasthamkotta. While farming was the primary occupation in my village, I always knew that it wasn't the path I wanted to follow. From a young age, I aspired to become a businessman.

During my college days, I took the initiative to start a small money lending company, focusing on daily collections. With a borrowed capital of Rs 1500, and with my confidence and willpower, I established my first venture at the age of 22. However, I soon realized that I needed to expand my knowledge and skills to truly succeed in the business world.

Later, I decided to join evening classes for an MBA in Kochi. It was during this time that some of my engineering classmates introduced me to the construction industry. With their guidance, I became a contractor for renowned companies like FACT, Cochin Refineries, and Hindustan Newsprint Ltd in Velloor, Kottayam. In 1978, when the Newsprint factory faced a labor strike due to local contractors, I made a life-changing decision to move to Al Khobar, Saudi